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(FROM LEFT) MADANI, MANJI AND GURUMURTHY

Islam. The war on terror has its speakers, writers and fighters and they too have targeted Islam. One of the speakers said terrorism cannot be fought successfully because there is no weapon to stop suicide bombers. But I feel responsible people should neither lose hope nor show pessimism.

We are resisting on two fronts: against those who cause terror as well as those who have started the war on terror. I meet people who disdain my appearance, especially my turban, my beard and my dress. To them, I am the symbol of a terrorist. Branding a particular appearance as terrorist or jihadi is helping terrorists achieve their nefarious designs. A terrorist should never be called a jihadi. Jihad

is mandatory for every Muslim as enshrined in the Quran but we will have to differentiate between jihad and terrorism. Jihad is being given a wrong connotation—shedding blood, indiscriminate killing, suicide bombing—and this has boosted the morale of the terrorists. Opposition to terrorism is the greatest jihad which is incumbent on every Muslim. We are also struggling to save the image of Islam and its misuse by vested interests. I am asked on television whether I love Islam or my country more. This is a tough question. If I say Islam, they call me unpatriotic. I am always asked to prove my loyalty to either Islam or to India. Now I say, I have two eyes and you should tell me which to keep and which to give away. But I give preference to my religion which has inculcated in me the spirit to lay down my life for the sake of my motherland. Islam has given great respect to women and puts them on a high pedestal. But Muslims do not follow the teachings of Islam in their mundane affairs. Thus, Islam is maligned.

I regard India as a magnificent country and the best place for Muslims on this planet. We have a pluralistic society. Unless every community is allowed to promote its culture, its integrity cannot be guaranteed. Our culture inspires us to love, not to hate. Women have different roles to play in a society. We cannot attain progress and achieve our goals unless we provide them the best of facilities. Some people raise the banner of advancement by creating nudity while others seek to imprison women by curbing their rights and deny them the right to live with dignity.

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DISCUSSION

Q. Is terrorism money and business-oriented, or is it a conflict of civilisations?

Gurumurthy: It is a mix of so many things: geopolitics, money, economic interests, personal prejudices. The monotheistic faiths have allowed their gods to clash. It is a failure of interpretation.

Q. When a child is born, it is neither Hindu or Christian. The

child just takes the religion that the family follows. Will our children become the victims of religion because we have not agreed on a common understanding of what religion means to us?

Manji: So many people around the world don't quite know who they are. And so it is easy for religion to be a source of absolutes and for people to be able to say: through this I know

who I am. The problem is: identity is only about what you are. Integrity is much more complex. We have both the opportunity and the challenge to make that transition from identity into integrity through our children.

Q. Most terrorism today is happening in the name of Islam. How do we counter it?

Madani: I appeal to the media not to use the term Islamic terrorism

as it helps them. Even the term jihadi is a misnomer for such misguided elements. If they happen to belong to the Muslim community, they should be dubbed as Muslim terrorists and not Islamic terrorists because this conveys a wrong message. They have to be eliminated and sidelined. They constitute a microscopic group. They are not part of the Muslim *Ummah* (brotherhood) and Islamic world.